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INSTALLING LINUX

Linux Installation

Using AWS or WSL/WSL2

As we have noted, there are various alternatives to directly installing and using the full Linux distribution of your choice on real computer hardware. One alternative that does not involve the use of a full-featured Linux distribution, is to utilize stripped down, easy to use (already installed) systems, either locally or in the cloud.

If you are using recent Microsoft Windows versions, you can take advantage of Windows Subsystem for Linux (WSL). WSL2 is the newer version, with enhanced capabilities and based on a subset of the Hyper-V hypervisor.

The advantage of using WSL/WSL2 is that you do not need to run either a "dual-boot" system (Windows + Linux), nor install any third-party software, such as VMware Workstation Player or Oracle VirtualBox. However, you will only have command-line access to a Linux-like system, without the use of graphical interfaces and programs.

Another alternative to having a physical Linux system is to use one hosted in the cloud. Probably the easiest path is to take advantage of Amazon Web Services (AWS), which offers a wide range of virtual machine products (instances) for remote users to access in the cloud.

In particular, you can use the AWS Free Tier account level for up to a year, and the simulated hardware and software choices available may provide most of what you need to gain experience with Linux. You can download a helpful guide we have prepared to help you experiment with the AWS free tier.

However, note that like WSL/WSL2, AWS does not give access to a graphical desktop, and you will not be able to easily use graphical applications, and as such, you will not be able to perform tasks which require their use.